Contents

Practical AI Business & Market Intelligence Brief - 2026-05-11

1. The short version

- The strongest signal today is that AI should be matched to the decision being made, not applied equally to every business question.
- Halliburton's AWS Bedrock proof-of-concept shows AI being used to reduce friction in a complex technical workflow, but the evidence is vendor-led and should not be treated as neutral proof.
- FMCG and distribution businesses face a practical AI opportunity around decisions that change daily: stock, pricing, supplier disruption, delivery costs, and customer demand.
- Vendor positioning is moving toward domain-specific AI agents and workflow support, especially where businesses hold large operational datasets.
- The risk is not only AI hallucination; it is using AI on poorly framed decisions, weak data, or processes where nobody is accountable for the final action.

2. Best business signal today

Fact:
MIT Sloan Management Review published "Calibrate AI Use to the Decision at Hand." The source pack summary says the article discusses a consumer goods leadership team using generative AI to support two different decisions: where to open the next five stores and whether to pivot the brand toward wellness.

Meaning:
This is a strong business signal because the two decisions are not the same type of problem. Store location is closer to a data-heavy decision: demand, footfall, local competition, logistics, rent, and customer profile can all be compared. A brand pivot is more strategic and uncertain: it involves customer identity, long-term positioning, competitor response, and judgement about future demand. AI may help both, but it should not be used in the same way for both.

Risk:
The source pack only provides a partial summary, so the detailed argument and evidence should be checked in the full article before making strong claims. It is also a professional insight source, not a direct implementation case with measured operational outcomes.

Application:
A business should first classify the decision before choosing how to use AI. For a structured operational decision, AI can help compare options, summarise data, and flag exceptions. For a strategic decision, AI is better used to challenge assumptions, generate scenarios, and expose blind spots — not to "decide" the answer.

3. AI implementation case

Who or what is involved:
Halliburton, AWS, Amazon Bedrock, and generative AI applied to seismic workflow creation.

Business problem:
The source describes a proof-of-concept for turning natural language queries into executable seismic workflows and supporting question-answering across Halliburton's Seismic Engine tools and documentation. The business problem is that complex technical workflows can be slow and difficult to build when users must know specialist tools, documentation, and step sequences.

Workflow or data involved:
The workflow involves natural language requests, technical documentation, seismic workflow steps, and executable workflow generation. In plain English, the user explains what they want to do, and the system helps translate that request into a structured technical process.

What changed or might change:
The AWS source says the proof-of-concept showed workflow acceleration of up to 95%. The bigger signal is not the exact number; it is the implementation pattern. AI is being placed between the user's intent and the technical workflow, reducing the gap between asking a question and building the process needed to answer it.

What could go wrong:
This is an AWS vendor blog, so it is useful primary evidence but not neutral proof. The result may depend on a controlled proof-of-concept, good documentation, expert review, and a narrow technical use case. If a similar system is used without strong checks, it could create the wrong workflow faster.

Lesson:
The lesson is that AI implementation becomes more credible when it is tied to a specific workflow and expert knowledge base. "AI can help employees" is vague. "AI can help technical users convert a natural language request into a checked workflow" is much more useful.

4. Market intelligence note

Signal:
Today's sources suggest that AI vendors are moving away from generic productivity promises and toward decision-specific or domain-specific products. Halliburton/AWS shows AI in a specialised technical workflow. RedCloud's announcement points to specialist AI agents trained on a large FMCG trade dataset. Microsoft's Power BI updates point to more AI and Copilot features inside business intelligence tooling.

Business meaning:
The market is trying to sell AI closer to the point of work. That means AI is being positioned around decisions such as which customer to prioritise, which stock line needs attention, which shipment cost is changing, which store should receive inventory, or which supplier issue needs escalation.

Why it matters:
This is commercially important because many businesses do not need a vague AI strategy first. They need better decisions in specific areas. For SMEs, retailers, wholesalers, and distributors, the likely demand is for tools that fit existing workflows and produce visible benefits quickly.

Uncertainty:
Several sources are vendor-led or news-search items. They are useful signals of market positioning, but they do not prove adoption, ROI, or customer satisfaction. The next layer of evidence should come from customer case studies, independent user feedback, and measurable operational outcomes.

5. FMCG / sales / distribution angle

Relevant business area:
Inventory management, replenishment, pricing, supplier management, sales reporting, and delivery cost control.

Practical use case:
A distributor or FMCG business could use AI-supported decision workflows to prioritise daily exceptions. For example, the system could flag products at risk of shortage, customers affected by delayed deliveries, suppliers with rising costs, or product lines where shipping surcharges are squeezing margin. A manager would still decide the action, but AI could help surface the issue faster and summarise the trade-offs.

Data or workflow needed:
The business would need clean product data, customer records, order history, supplier information, delivery data, pricing records, and margin data. It would also need a clear workflow: who reviews the alert, who approves the action, and where the decision is recorded.

Risk or limitation:
The main limitation is data readiness. If order statuses, product codes, supplier lead times, or margin records are unreliable, AI will produce confident-looking but weak recommendations. In FMCG and distribution, speed matters, but bad speed is dangerous. A faster wrong decision can damage service levels, margins, and customer trust.

6. Method or framework of the day

Term:
Use-case scoring

Plain English meaning:
Use-case scoring means ranking possible AI ideas before building them, based on how useful, realistic, risky, and measurable they are.

Business example:
A wholesaler has five AI ideas: demand forecasting, customer email drafting, supplier risk alerts, delivery delay explanations, and sales dashboard summaries. Instead of trying all five at once, the business scores each idea based on data availability, business value, ease of testing, risk, and whether success can be measured.

Why it matters:
It stops AI adoption from becoming random experimentation. A business should not start with the flashiest idea. It should start with the use case where the problem is clear, the data is usable, the risk is controlled, and the improvement can be checked.

7. Practical takeaway

The practical takeaway is that AI value depends on fit. The right question is not "how can we use AI?" but "which decision or workflow is painful enough, structured enough, and measurable enough for AI to help?" Businesses should start with narrow decisions where better data, faster comparison, or clearer exception handling can improve work. AI should support judgement, not replace accountability.

8. Research desk opportunity

Possible title:
How to Score AI Use Cases in FMCG and Distribution

Research question:
Which AI use cases are most realistic for FMCG, wholesale, and distribution businesses when scored by business value, data readiness, risk, and ease of testing?

Why it is worth exploring:
This would turn broad AI interest into a practical decision tool. It could help businesses separate realistic workflow improvements from vague AI ideas.

Sources to check next:
MIT Sloan decision-making articles, Microsoft Power BI/Fabric documentation, AWS implementation case studies, FMCG AI vendor case studies, Supply Chain Dive cost-pressure stories, The Grocer, Retail Times, ONS business data, OECD SME digital adoption material, and independent BI implementation reviews.

9. Source notes

- **Source name:** MIT Sloan Management Review — "Calibrate AI Use to the Decision at Hand"

Source type: Professional insight source
Link: https://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/calibrate-ai-use-to-the-decision-at-hand/
Why it was used: It provides the strongest decision-making frame: AI should be calibrated to the type of decision, not applied generically.
Bias or limitation: Professional insight source. Useful for framing, but the source pack summary is partial and should be checked against the full article before making detailed claims.

- **Source name:** AWS Machine Learning Blog — "Halliburton enhances seismic workflow creation with Amazon Bedrock and Generative AI"
  Source type: AI/data tooling vendor case study
  Link: https://aws.amazon.com/blogs/machine-learning/halliburton-enhances-seismic-workflow-creation-with-amazon-bedrock-and-generative-ai/
  Why it was used: Strong implementation case showing generative AI being applied to a specific complex workflow.
  Bias or limitation: Vendor/company source. The claimed acceleration comes from a proof-of-concept and should not be generalised without independent evidence.

- **Source name:** Google News / Yahoo Finance UK — "RedCloud Unveils Specialist AI Agents Trained on $6.9 Billion FMCG Trade Dataset"
  Source type: News/search item with vendor-market signal
  Link: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMijwFBVV95cUxOYmZuekRkN09IV3VTQnc2aXp2
  Why it was used: Direct FMCG AI market signal showing vendor positioning around domain-specific AI agents and trade data.
  Bias or limitation: Likely vendor-led announcement distributed through news channels. Useful as a market signal, not proof of measurable customer outcomes.

- **Source name:** Supply Chain Dive — "UPS and FedEx up international fuel surcharge rates, add surge fees"
  Source type: Supply chain industry news
  Link: https://www.supplychaindive.com/news/ups-and-fedex-up-international-fuel-surcharge-rates-add-surge-fees/819749/
  Why it was used: Shows operational cost pressure affecting import and export shipments, which strengthens the case for better cost visibility and margin tracking.
  Bias or limitation: Industry news item. Useful business context, but not an AI implementation source.

- **Source name:** Supply Chain Dive — "Protein powder shortage threatens America's biggest food craze"
  Source type: FMCG/supply chain industry news
  Link: https://www.supplychaindive.com/news/protein-powder-shortage-threatens-americas-biggest-food-craze/819745/
  Why it was used: Useful FMCG pressure signal around shortages, pricing pressure, and consumer inflation sensitivity.
  Bias or limitation: Industry news item. It supports the business context, but does not prove that AI would solve the shortage.

- **Source name:** Google News / Retail Times — “Iceland partners with invent.ai to transform inventory and replenishment operations”
  Source type: News/search item
  Link: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMirwFBVV95cUxQV1RzMnJlQzZPdkxLMnRqSWU3
  Why it was used: Direct retail AI signal around inventory and replenishment, which is highly relevant to FMCG and distribution workflows.
  Bias or limitation: The source pack only provides the headline-level summary. The full article should be checked before making detailed claims about the implementation.

10. Quality check

- Used 3 to 6 source items
- Separated fact, meaning, risk, and application
- Included FMCG/sales/distribution relevance
- Explained one technical term in plain English
- Avoided invented claims
- Suitable for public GitHub portfolio